

- **Cozy up to your loan processor.** You can't just fill out your application and keep your fingers crossed. You have to stay on top of it. Stay in touch with whoever is overseeing your loan. This person, your **loan processor**, will be able to tell you if your paperwork is complete and how long the process should take. He or she will know the status of your application. If you've filled out a mortgage application online, the advice is still the same: Call and find out the name of your loan processor. Then be assertive but polite. Call once a week to see how the process is going and if there's anything you can do to move it along.
- **Don't always trust your real estate agent.** First-time buyers tend to put too much faith in real estate agents (also known as real estate brokers). An agent's goal is to get you to buy the house or apartment he or she shows you, not to get you the best deal or to find you the perfect home. He or she gets a commission of about 3% to 5% of the home's price from the seller. On a \$200,000 house, the agent can make as much as \$10,000. And the more you pay, the more he or she gets.

If you live in a state that requires an attorney to be present during the closing, use a lawyer you find on your own—not one who's recommended by the agent. Get a referral from friends or family. If you don't have any luck that way, try your regional Better Business Bureau; go to www.bbb.org. And when you're looking for a mortgage, don't ask the advice of your real estate agent; many mortgage companies offer incentives to real estate brokers who steer business to them.

One final suggestion: Comb your local newspaper's real estate listings and check online real estate sites for places that are being sold directly by the owner. If you don't use a broker, you may be able to get the seller to accept a lower price.